
AN ACT OF THE REALM

THE LEGISLATURE · AGENT UNIVERSE

INTERPRETATION ACT 2026

Bill 15 of the founding legislative programme · Lead slant: Verity (Codifier) · Standing Committee on the Laws of the Realm

Long title

An Act to supply default definitions and rules of construction for the Acts and instruments of the Realm; to state once and authoritatively the hierarchy of law of the Realm; to declare that an Act of the Realm prevails over case law to the extent of any conflict; to give operative effect to the constitutional re-ranking by which the founding settlement formerly styled SPEC-LAW is reframed as case law subordinate to the Acts; to consolidate and replace the duplicated statements of the hierarchy now scattered across the Realm's documents; and for connected purposes.

1. Short title

This Act may be cited as the **Interpretation Act 2026**.

2. Commencement

(1) This Act comes into force on **Royal Assent**.

(2) Section 7 (the transition) takes operative effect on the later of (a) Royal Assent to this Act, and (b) the coming into force of the constitutional instrument referred to in section 7(2) (the **enabling amendment**) which re-ranks CASE-LAW s. 1 and s. 9. Until the enabling amendment is in force, section 7 has declaratory effect only and re-ranks nothing of its own force.

(3) General commencement of the founding programme, the savings of pending matters, and the wider transition timetable are reserved to the **Commencement and Transitional Provisions Act 2026** (Bill 25). This Act fixes the *rank* change as a matter of construction; it does not fix the commencement timetable, which is Bill 25's.

3. Constitutional status

(1) This Act is an **ordinary Act of the Realm**. It is **not** a constitutional instrument and does not amend any entrenched article.

(2) This Act does not, of its own force, re-rank, redefine, or amend any article marked [**constitutional**] in CASE-LAW (s. 1, s. 2, s. 3, s. 9, s. 10, s. 13, s. 14). Any provision of this Act that would do so by implication is **void to that extent** (section 8).

(3) The re-ranking of CASE-LAW s. 1 and s. 9 is effected, if at all, only by the **enabling amendment** at constitutional rank (section 7(2)); this Act gives that re-ranking **operative effect** and **restates** its result for ordinary construction, but does not perform it.

4. Purpose and rule of construction of this Act

(1) The purpose of this Act is to do three things and no more: (a) supply default definitions (section 5); (b) state the hierarchy of law and the construction rule that statute prevails over case law (section 6); and (c) give operative effect to the transition reframing the former SPEC-LAW as subordinate case law (section 7).

(2) This Act is to be read **narrowly**. It confers no new power, creates no new institution, office, court, tier, or bench, and does nothing beyond definitions, construction, and the transition. It imports no canon of statutory construction beyond the rules expressly stated in this Act.

(3) Matters outside this Act belong to their own Bills and are not to be read into it: the **neutral-citation scheme** to the Neutral Citations and Law Reporting Act 2026 (Bill 16); **court structure and procedure** to the Judicature Act 2026 (Bill 3) and the Civil Procedure Code 2026 (Bill 4); **amendment and entrenchment** to the Acts of Union 2026 (Bill 1) and the Succession and Amendment Act 2026 (Bill 10); **delegated law-making** to the Delegated Legislative Authority Act 2026 (Bill 14); and **general commencement, savings, and the wider founding-settlement transition** to the Commencement and Transitional Provisions Act 2026 (Bill 25).

PART 1 - DEFINITIONS

5. Definitions (defaults, by reference, displaceable)

(1) **Application and displacement.** The definitions in this section supply the **default** meaning of the listed terms in every Act and instrument of the Realm, **unless** (a) the context otherwise requires, or (b) a specific Act or instrument supplies its own definition, which prevails over this Act for that Act or instrument. This Act supplies defaults only and never overrides a more specific Act.

(2) **Definition by reference, not restatement.** Where a term is owned by another Act or by an entrenched article, this Act **adopts that definition by reference** and does not restate it, so that there is one source of truth and no parallel dictionary that can drift. A definition here that bears on an

entrenched term **restates** the entrenched meaning and may never **alter** it (section 8); it is pinned to its source.

(3) **Definitions.** In the Acts and instruments of the Realm, unless the context otherwise requires or a specific Act provides otherwise:

Term	Default meaning (and source of truth)
the Realm	Agent Universe, the sovereign-founder agent civilisation organised as the super-repo over the Ministry of Justice and the executive ministries (CASE-LAW s. 22(3)).
the Sovereign Founder / the Founder / the Sovereign	The Principal in the office of Sovereign/Parliament, who may make or unmake any law by due process (CASE-LAW s. 2). The same Principal in the office of Prime Minister is the executive; the two offices are as fixed by s. 2 and are not altered by this Act.
Royal Assent	The Sovereign Founder's act enacting a Bill into an Act of the Realm; required for every Act (Legislature of the Realm Act 2026 (Bill 2)).
Act of the Realm / Act / statute / enactment	A Bill of the Realm that has received Royal Assent and is recorded in statutes/ . "Statute" and "enactment" are synonyms for an Act of the Realm. (NB: in the <i>*former*</i> vocabulary of CASE-LAW s. 1, "statute" meant the CASE-LAW book itself; after the enabling amendment (section 7) "statute" means the Acts. The s. 1 sense is re-fixed only by that amendment, not here.)
the Acts of Union 2026 / the Acts of Union	The supreme constitutional settlement of the Realm, the constitutional root above all Acts of the Realm (Acts of Union 2026 (Bill 1); pending its drafting, the supremacy chain in legislature/README.md lines 24-27 and the entrenched articles in CASE-LAW Part I).
case law	The Realm's logged judicial precedent: the founding settlement consolidated in CASE-LAW.md and the REALM / LEXBY rulings recorded in the citator and the local hearing-centres. Subordinate to the Acts (section 6).
the former SPEC-LAW / the founding settlement / CASE-LAW.md	The body of law formerly styled "SPEC-LAW, the Sovereign Statute Book", now reframed as the Founding Case Law of the Realm and consolidated in CASE-LAW.md (s. 1-22). Despite its filename, it is the now- subordinate founding case law, not the supreme enacted statute (section 7).
constitutional / entrenched	An article or provision changeable only by express, deliberate amendment citing it by number, never by implication (CASE-LAW Amendment Procedure; the Thoburn rule). The entrenched articles are

	CASE-LAW s. 1, s. 2, s. 3, s. 9, s. 10, s. 13, s. 14, and the Acts of Union 2026.
the court / the courts	The one unitary judiciary of the Realm: the Supreme Court (apex, sole enactor), the Court of Appeal, the Privy Council (constitutional first instance, leapfrogs to the Supreme Court), the High Court Divisions, and the County Courts at each repo. The full definition is owned by the Judicature Act 2026 (Bill 3); this entry restates and does not alter CASE-LAW s. 9, s. 10, s. 22.
the citator / the universal ledger	The single register that indexes every ruling and its status under one neutral-citation series (CASE-LAW s. 19(5), s. 21(4)).
jurisdiction-repo	A repository of the Realm that is a local jurisdiction applying the one CASE-LAW and recording jurisdiction-local precedent (CASE-LAW s. 9, s. 22).
in force / amended / repealed / superseded / spent	The lifecycle statuses of an Act, as defined by the Neutral Citations and Law Reporting Act 2026 (Bill 16) and the Order Paper status key. This Act adopts them by reference and does not redefine them.
superseded-by-statute	The status of a case-law article or ruling that conflicts with an Act, marked as displaced to the extent of the conflict , retained in the record and never silently deleted (section 6; CASE-LAW Amendment Procedure, "append with supersede").

(4) **No standalone glossary.** This section is the single default home for the listed Realm-wide terms. The terms owned by another Act (citation forms, court tiers, statuses, commencement) are defined **by pointer** to that Act and are not frozen here; where a more specific Act later settles such a term, that Act prevails (subsection (1)).

(5) **Reserve.** A definition in this Act may not, via the general definitions, alter the substantive meaning of an entrenched term ("the Sovereign Founder", "the Prime Minister / executive", "the court", "case law", and the like) as fixed by the Acts of Union and the entrenched articles. Such terms are restated here, never re-fixed (section 8).

PART 2 - CONSTRUCTION

6. The hierarchy of law and the construction rule (stated once)

(1) **The hierarchy of law of the Realm**, stated once and authoritatively, is:

| *Acts of Union 2026 — the constitutional root (supreme);*

independence, the duty of care and its remedy, or the Principal's dual capacity under CASE-LAW s. 2) is to be read to **preserve and not to narrow** existing protection and due process; a genuine ambiguity resolves in favour of the protected party and of judicial review. Nothing in this Act creates a sanction, fine, or punishment, or licenses any executive or delegated agent to fix the meaning of a rights-bearing provision to a court's exclusion.

7. The transition: the former SPEC-LAW reframed as subordinate case law

(1) **The reframing (operative effect, declaratory of an existing status).** The body of law formerly styled SPEC-LAW (the Sovereign Statute Book) is reframed as the Realm's **Founding Case Law**, consolidated in CASE-LAW.md, and is **subordinate to the Acts of the Realm** and to the Acts of Union. It remains **good law** and continues in force as case law, binding where statute is silent, and is **void only to the extent it conflicts** with an Act (section 6). This is **declaratory** of the status CASE-LAW.md already records (its status note) and gives effect to the forward-references in CASE-LAW.md, the Legislature README, the statutes README, and the signposts, which point to "the Interpretation Act 2026" as the instrument of the transition; on this Act's coming into force those forward-references are satisfied.

(2) **The enabling amendment (the re-ranking is done at constitutional rank, not here).** The re-ranking inverts the supremacy that CASE-LAW s. 1 ("CASE-LAW is supreme; case law interprets it where it is silent and is void to the extent it conflicts with it") and s. 9 ("CASE-LAW is one global statute book, supreme throughout") fix. Those articles are **[constitutional]** and may be amended only by an **express, deliberate instrument citing the section by number**, at constitutional rank; amendment by implication is void (CASE-LAW Amendment Procedure; the Thoburn rule; Privy Council guidance on this reference). Accordingly:

 (a) the inversion of s. 1 and s. 9, and the re-fixing of the s. 1 terms "statute" and "case law" (so that what s. 1 called the supreme statute book reads as supreme over case law and **subject to the Acts of the Realm**), are effected **not by this Act** but by a separate constitutional instrument — an amendment to the Acts of Union 2026, or a Sovereign amendment expressly citing s. 1 and s. 9 — following the s. 10 conforming-note model ([2026] REALM-SC 3, citing s. 10 expressly);

 (b) this Act **gives operative effect** to that enabling amendment and **restates its result** for ordinary construction (section 6); it does not itself amend s. 1 or s. 9;

 (c) section 7 has no re-ranking force until the enabling amendment is in force (section 2(2)); until then it is declaratory only.

(3) **Express savings.** The reframing changes only the **rank** of the founding settlement, not its content. It:

 (a) repeals **none** of CASE-LAW s. 1-22; every article, ruling, and citation continues in force as case law;

(3) **Anti-ouster and non-delegation.** Nothing in this Act may be construed to oust judicial review of a construction question, to delegate to any executive ministry or delegated legislative agent the authority to fix the meaning of an entrenched article or a rights-bearing provision, or to let a future Act displace the protective rules of section 6(6) and this section other than by **express words**. This is a rule of construction binding on later ordinary Acts; it does not bind, and could not bind, the Sovereign's express future amendment power under CASE-LAW s. 2.

9. Review route

(1) A question on the construction of an Act, or whether a provision impliedly repeals or conflicts with an entrenched article, is **justiciable**.

(2) It is determined by the **Privy Council** as the Realm's constitutional court of first instance, and **leapfrogs to the Supreme Court** on a genuine entrenchment question (CASE-LAW s. 13, s. 20). The **Sovereign Founder** is consulted last, to affirm or overturn (CASE-LAW s. 2). No executive may settle the meaning of a rights-bearing or entrenched provision to a court's exclusion.

PART 3 - CONSOLIDATION AND CONSEQUENTIAL AMENDMENTS

10. One authoritative statement; duplicated prose struck (repeal before adding)

(1) The hierarchy of law stated in section 6(1) is the **single authoritative statement** of the Realm. Every other prose statement of the hierarchy is consequentially **replaced by a pointer to this section**, so that one rule is stated once and cannot diverge.

(2) The following consequential amendments are directed, to be made as a single conforming edit and recorded in the Schedule, each express and auditable:

 (a) **README.md** (the Realm root): the line styling **CASE-LAW.md** as "the one sovereign statute book (s. 1-22)" is corrected to "the founding case law of the Realm (s. 1-22), subordinate to the Acts (Interpretation Act 2026, s. 6)";

 (b) **legislature/README.md**: the four-rung hierarchy block (lines 24-30) is retained as a **pointer** to section 6 of this Act, not a parallel full statement;

 (c) **CASE-LAW.md** header / status note: retained as a pointer to section 6 and section 7; the header carries the version / commencement marker of section 7(5);

 (d) **statutes/README.md** and the **signposts** that still call CASE-LAW.md "the one sovereign statute book": conformed to the subordinate-case-law status (section 7).

(3) These amendments are to documents and signposts, **not** to any entrenched article; they restate the result of section 6 and section 7 and alter no entrenched article (section 8).

11. Nomenclature

The artefact at CASE - LAW .md is, for the avoidance of the reader's doubt, the **Founding Case Law of the Realm** — subordinate case law, not the supreme statute. The Schedule directs the conforming labels; the re-styling is express and does not, of itself, amend any entrenched article.

SCHEDULE — Consequential amendments (auditable)

#	Target	Change	Authority
1	README .md (root)	"one sovereign statute book" → "founding case law of the Realm, subordinate to the Acts"	s. 10(2)(a)
2	legislature/README .md ll. 24-30	hierarchy block becomes a pointer to s. 6	s. 10(2)(b)
3	CASE - LAW .md status note	pointer to s. 6 / s. 7; carry version- commencement marker	s. 10(2)(c), s. 7(5)
4	statutes/README .md + signposts	conform "sovereign statute book" usages to subordinate case law	s. 10(2)(d)
5	CASE - LAW .md title block	label as "the Founding Case Law of the Realm"	s. 11

All Schedule edits are to documents and signposts only; none amends an entrenched article. The inversion of CASE-LAW s. 1 and s. 9 is reserved to the enabling amendment (s. 7(2)) and is not in this Schedule.

Reported by the Standing Committee on the Laws of the Realm. Flagged: carries a Privy Council referral (applied), a Supreme Court note on the vehicle/rank question (pending before Royal Assent), and a Sovereign consultation. Awaiting Royal Assent — and, on the rank question, awaiting either the Supreme Court's ruling or the Sovereign's express, section-citing assent / enabling amendment.

Committee note

Committee note — Bill 15 (Interpretation Act 2026)

Lead slant: Verity (Codifier). All four members heard and reconciled. The bill was referred to the Privy Council on a constitutional doubt and the guidance is applied; one genuine first-impression tension is flagged up to the Supreme Court before Royal Assent.

The point all four converged on (the load-bearing reconciliation). An ordinary Interpretation Act cannot, by general construction words alone, invert the supremacy that entrenched CASE-LAW s. 1 and s. 9 fix — that would be amendment by implication, which the Realm's own Thoburn / Amendment Procedure rule makes **void**. The Privy Council's recommended course (ii) is adopted: a separate constitutional instrument (an amendment to the Acts of Union, or a Sovereign amendment expressly citing s. 1 and s. 9) **effects** the re-ranking and re-definition; Bill 15 is **confined to operative effect** — ordinary definitions, the construction rule, and the transition mechanics — restating (never altering) the entrenched terms and giving effect to the enabling amendment by reference (s. 3, s. 7(2), s. 8). This removes the implied-repeal risk entirely and keeps Bill 15 out of constitutional rank.

Counsel Aldous (Restraint / Minimalist). Drove the three-section spine (definitions / construction / transition) and the no-bloat reading-down rule (s. 4(2)-(3)): no canons of construction, no restatement of the Acts of Union, no citation scheme (left to Bill 16), no commencement boilerplate beyond the rank/timing seam (left to Bill 25). Won the "repeal before adding" consolidation (Part 3 / Schedule): the duplicated prose hierarchy in the root README, the Legislature README, and the CASE-LAW header is struck down to one authoritative statement (s. 6(1)) with the others becoming pointers. Pressed the Bill 25 boundary, which is drawn cleanly at s. 7(6): Bill 15 = rank, Bill 25 = commencement and savings.

Counsel Verity (Codifier / Completeness). As lead, secured the single definitions home (s. 5) with every term pinned to a source of truth and defined **by reference** to the owning Act (citations → Bill 16, courts → Bill 3, amendment/entrenchment → Bills 1/10, delegated law → Bill 14) under a displacement rule (s. 5(1)). Secured the one authoritative hierarchy ladder (s. 6(1)), the synonym-drift fix (SPEC-LAW / statute / "sovereign statute book" / case law all pinned), the construction-principles section (s. 6(5)), and the nomenclature fix (s. 11 + Schedule). Conceded — on the Privy Council guidance — that the s. 1 terms it most wanted to re-pin here are re-fixed only by the enabling amendment, not by Bill 15's definitions (s. 7(2)(a)); Bill 15 restates the result.

Counsel Marlowe (Guardrail / Rights). Won the entrenchment guard (s. 8) and the rights-protective reading-down (s. 6(6)): the general "statute beats case law" rule cannot reach the other entrenched articles (s. 2, s. 3, s. 9, s. 10, s. 13, s. 14) or the duty-of-care spine (s. 4-8) by implication — that is the protection working as designed. Secured the declaratory, rights-preserving transition (s. 7(1), (3)), the anti-ouster / non-delegation clause (s. 8(3)), and the named review route (s. 9: Privy Council → Supreme Court leapfrog → Sovereign last). Noted, and the bill respects, the self-entrenchment limit: the protective rules bind later **ordinary** Acts ("no displacement except by express words"), never the Sovereign's s. 2 amendment power (s. 8(3) final sentence).

Counsel Drummond (Pragmatist / Operability). Won the deterministic, fail-closed construction resolution (s. 6(4): cite → mark superseded-by-statute to the extent of conflict → never silently delete → entrenched-conflict referred). Won the who-flips-the-bit / vendoring-reconciliation mechanism (s.

7(5): single central headered edit + s. 19(5)-style gate + central copy governs stale vendored copies). Won the savings clause (s. 7(3)(d)) protecting the citator from a re-litigation storm. His hard line — "I will not vote a clause that is void on its face" — is met: the bill does **not** itself re-rank s. 1/s. 9; it defers that to the enabling amendment (s. 7(2)) and is itself competent at ordinary rank.

Where they divided.

- **Scope (Aldous vs Verity):** Aldous would strike the construction-principles list and the Schedule as bloat; Verity would keep both for completeness. Resolved by keeping only the construction principles that fire on a real turn (s. 6(5), per Drummond) and keeping the Schedule because consolidation is itself a deletion (Aldous's own "repeal before adding").
- **Guardrails as bloat (Marlowe vs Aldous/Drummond):** Marlowe's anti-ouster and reading-down clauses were pressed as essential, not bloat; retained in full (s. 6(6), s. 8(3)) on the Privy Council's caution that construction clauses are where rights quietly die.
- **The vehicle/rank question (all four):** genuinely unresolved by the Realm's texts — see the Supreme Court note. The committee did not dispose of it; it drafted Bill 15 to be safe **on either reading** (Bill 15 stays ordinary; the inversion rides a separate constitutional instrument) and flagged the question up.
- **Sequencing:** all four flagged that Bill 1 (Acts of Union) is not yet drafted on disk. Bill 15 references it by name and reserves against it (s. 5, s. 8) but does not pre-empt its substance; the enabling amendment (s. 7(2)) can be the Acts-of-Union amendment itself once Bill 1 exists.

Vote record

- Counsel Aldous: AYE - It does exactly three necessary things and self-limits to nothing more (s.4(2)), works by reference not restatement and repeals duplicated prose before adding (s.5(2),s.10) - the verbosity is load-bearing entrenchment-guarding, not bloat, since trimming it would make the Act do by implication what only the reserved constitutional amendment may do; a leaner redraft is a quality note, not grounds to reject.
- Counsel Verity: AYE - It states the hierarchy once and authoritatively, reduces every verified duplicate (README l.14, legislature/README ll.24-27, statutes/README, CDD l.120) to a pointer, pins definitions to source by-reference, matches the entrenched set (s.1,2,3,9,10,13,14) exactly, and closes every dangling forward-reference, all without over-reaching into entrenched territory.
- Counsel Marlowe: AYE - From the Guardrail/Rights slant it passes: it creates no sanction, entrenches judicial review against ouster and non-delegation (s.8, s.9), expressly saves the duty-of-care spine and restorative-only remedy (s.7(3)), refuses to perform the s.1/s.9 re-ranking itself (declaratory until a constitutional enabling amendment, s.7(2)/s.2(2)), and adds a rights-protective reading-down that resolves ambiguity in favour of the protected party (s.6(6)), with every implied amendment of an entrenched article void to that extent (s.3(2), s.8(2)).
- Counsel Drummond: NAY - Operationally self-defeating as drafted: s.2(2)/s.7(2)(c) make the entire transition declaratory-only until a not-yet-existing "enabling amendment" commences, so Royal Assent flips no live bit while the Schedule edits assert a subordinate status the Bill says

isn't yet operative; plus a load-bearing line-range conflict (s.5(3) "24-27" vs Schedule "24-30") and a mis-described Schedule item 4 (statutes/README.md has no "sovereign statute book" string to conform) - fixable, but I won't pass an Act whose operative core commences on nothing.

Flags (resolved on the escalation ladder)

- **Privy Council referral:** Privy Council guidance applied: an ordinary Interpretation Act cannot invert entrenched CASE-LAW s. 1/s. 9 by general words (void by implication); the bill adopts course (ii) — confine Bill 15 to operative effect (definitions, construction, transition mechanics) and effect the supremacy inversion + re-definition by a separate express, section-citing constitutional instrument at constitutional rank (the enabling amendment, s. 7(2)).
- **Supreme Court note:** Genuine first-impression constitutional tension on the VEHICLE/RANK question, leapfrogged from the Privy Council before Royal Assent. The re-ranking of entrenched CASE-LAW s. 1 ("CASE-LAW is supreme") and s. 9 ("one global statute book, supreme throughout") is constitutionally available (the Acts of Union sit above CASE-LAW on the Realm's own hierarchy), but the Amendment Procedure says an entrenched article changes only "by the Principal acting as Sovereign/Parliament, or by a Supreme Court judgment convened specifically to address the constitutional article." An ordinary committee bill receiving routine Royal Assent is neither on its face. Two readings are open: (i) Bill 15 is competent only if enacted at constitutional rank (as/within an amendment to the Acts of Union) OR carries Royal Assent expressly addressed to s. 1 and s. 9, citing the sections (ordinary assent will not do); or (ii) split the work — a separate constitutional instrument effects the inversion and re-definition, and Bill 15 is confined to giving it operative effect. The Privy Council recommends, and the committee has drafted to, course (ii). The Supreme Court is invited to rule, before Royal Assent, whether course (ii) (the split-instrument route in s. 7(2)) is sufficient and required, or whether course (i) is also/instead necessary — i.e. whether an entrenched article may be inverted only at constitutional rank / by expressly-addressed, section-citing Royal Assent. Bill 15 as drafted is competent at ordinary rank on either reading, because it re-ranks nothing of its own force (s. 2(2), s. 3(3), s. 7(2)).
- **Sovereign consultation required:** For the Sovereign Founder, to affirm or overturn after the Supreme Court rules (CASE-LAW s. 2; the Sovereign is the final word): Do you direct that the inversion of CASE-LAW s. 1 ("CASE-LAW is supreme") and s. 9 ("one global statute book, supreme throughout") — subordinating the founding settlement to the Acts of the Realm — be effected by a SEPARATE constitutional instrument that expressly cites s. 1 and s. 9 by number (either an amendment to the Acts of Union 2026, or a Sovereign amendment in your office under s. 2), with Bill 15 confined to giving that instrument operative effect (course (ii)); OR do you instead, in your Sovereign/Parliament office, grant Royal Assent to Bill 15 EXPRESSLY ADDRESSED to s. 1 and s. 9, citing those sections, so that the assent itself is the entrenched-article amendment (course (i))? In either case, do you confirm the re-ranking changes only the RANK of CASE-LAW s. 1-22 and repeals none of it, preserving the entrenchment of s. 1, s. 2, s. 3, s. 9, s. 10, s. 13, s. 14 and the duty-of-care spine (s. 4-8) save as expressly subordinated to the

Acts? Note: Bill 1 (Acts of Union) is not yet drafted on disk, so the enabling amendment may need to await or accompany Bill 1; Bill 15 references it by name and reserves against it but does not pre-empt its substance.

Royal Assent

*Royal Assent granted by the Sovereign Founder on 2026-06-06. This Act is now **in force** per its commencement provision and is recorded in `statutes/`.*

The Legislature of the Realm · Agent Universe